

M1T3: Building a Wellness Mindset — 8 min

Video File M1T3-Mindset.mp4 · **Resources** Affirmations Audio.mp3 (embed) · Affirmation Cards & Vision Board Guide.pdf · **Xp** 90 total · Practice Daily Affirmation 30 · Create Vision Board (photo upload) 40 · Share Board in Group 20

Target runtime 8 min · 1,030 spoken words · ≈ 6.9 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 7.6 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

Before I ever became a mother, I had a sentence that lived in my head: "People like me don't get to have that." I never said it out loud. I didn't have to. It shaped what I ate, how I moved, and how much I believed my body could be trusted. If you have a sentence like that, this training is where we start rewriting it.

0:30–2:30 **BARRIERS: PERFECTIONISM AND DOUBT**

[VISUAL: Slide: two words, "Perfectionism" and "Doubt," with a crack running between them.]

Two barriers show up in almost every conversation I have about pre-conception health. The first is perfectionism: "If I can't do this diet perfectly, why bother?" The second is doubt: "It probably won't work for me anyway." They look like opposites. One says the bar is impossibly high; the other says you'll never reach it. But they're cousins. Both give you a

reason to stop before you start, and both feel like honesty when they're really just fear wearing a sensible coat.

Here's the science that helped me. The psychologist Carol Dweck spent decades studying what she calls fixed and growth mindsets. In a fixed mindset, your abilities, and by extension your body, are what they are, and every setback is a verdict. In a growth mindset, your abilities are developed through effort and feedback, and every setback is data. In a landmark study published in *Child Development*, Dweck and her colleagues found that simply teaching students that the brain can change, physically, with effort, measurably improved their persistence and their grades. The same lesson applies here. Your fertility health is not a verdict. It's a garden, and gardens respond to tending.

My own turning point was realizing that my doubt wasn't a prediction. It was a memory. It was every time I'd tried and stopped, replayed as if it were a forecast. And the moment I treated my body like something that could learn, I stopped needing to be perfect and started being consistent. Consistent is what changed my life. Perfect never showed up.

[VISUAL: Affirmation cards fan out on screen: "My body is learning." "I am preparing, not waiting." "Small steps are enough."]

Tool one: affirmations, done the grown-up way. An affirmation is not pretending. It's choosing which true sentence to repeat. There are a thousand true sentences about you; "I'm behind" is one and "I'm learning" is another, and the one you repeat is the one your nervous system builds a home around. Researchers Geoffrey Cohen and David Sherman reviewed the science of self-affirmation in the *Annual Review of Psychology* and found that briefly reflecting on your core values makes people more open to health information and more likely to act on it. And in a study led by David Creswell published in *Psychological Science*, people who wrote about their values before a stressful task had a measurably lower cortisol response than people who didn't. Lower stress hormones, from a sentence. So the Affirmations Audio under this video isn't fluff. It's a five-minute daily reset for your nervous system.

If you want to write your own, here are my three rules. Keep it in the present tense: "I am preparing," not "I will be ready

someday." Keep it believable: if "I love my body" makes you roll your eyes, try "I am learning to listen to my body," because your nervous system can tell when you're lying to it. And keep it about the process, not the outcome. "I take one baby step every day" is something you can prove true by lunchtime. "I will get pregnant this month" is not in your hands, and an affirmation you can't keep becomes one more thing to feel guilty about. We don't do guilt here.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Grace over guilt: the science of self-compassion."]

Tool two: self-compassion, which in this course I call grace over guilt. When you slip, and you will, because you're human, the voice you use with yourself decides what happens next. Juliana Breines and Serena Chen, in the *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, found that people who responded to a personal failure with self-compassion were more motivated to improve afterward, not less. That surprises people. We assume being hard on ourselves is what keeps us honest. The research says the opposite: compassion isn't letting yourself off the hook. It's the thing that keeps you on the path.

[VISUAL: Slide: warmth and connection; a soft glowing heart icon.]

Tool three: warmth, literally. Kind words, a hug, a hand on your own heart. Research led by Kerstin Uvnäs-Moberg, published in *Frontiers in Psychology*, describes how gentle, non-threatening touch and warm social contact trigger the release of oxytocin, the hormone of calm and connection, which in turn dials down the stress response. You are allowed to be tender with yourself. Your hormones like it. When you say your affirmation this week, put your hand flat on your chest as you say it. It feels a little silly the first time and a little sacred by the fourth.

[VISUAL: Vision board examples: a simple corkboard, a phone-wallpaper collage, a notebook page with three images and a sentence.]

Tool four: visualization, made concrete. A vision board is simply a place where your future gets to be visible. A meta-analysis of imagery interventions in *Health Psychology Review* by Dominic Conroy and Martin Hagger found that mentally picturing yourself performing a health behavior improves the odds you'll actually do it. So don't only put a baby on your board. Put the walk. Put the water bottle. Put the two of you laughing in the kitchen at seven in the morning.

Put the version of you who is preparing, not waiting. The board isn't a wish list. It's a rehearsal.

6:30–7:30 PERSONAL APPLICATION AND HEART-LED CLOSE

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera, holding an affirmation card.]

Here's how I want you to use all this. Pick one affirmation, the one that makes you a little emotional when you read it. That's the right one; the tears are information. Say it once every morning, hand on heart, before your phone. Then, sometime this week, build your vision board, physical or digital, with at least three images of the daily life you're growing into. It doesn't need to be pretty. It needs to be yours.

This is for your future family. Embrace grace over guilt, because the parent you're becoming will need to model both: the courage to try and the kindness to try again.

7:30–8:00 ACTION HANDOFF

[VISUAL: End card: "Affirmations Audio (30 XP) → Vision board photo upload (40 XP) → Share in the group (20 XP)."]

So: listen to the embedded Affirmations Audio daily this week for thirty XP. Create your vision board and upload a photo for forty. Then share it in the group for twenty, and go admire

someone else's, because inspiration is contagious. Next up, Training Four: bringing your partner in.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Affirmations Audio.mp3 (embedded) and the Affirmation Cards & Vision Board Guide.pdf. **ACTION 1:** Listen to the Affirmations Audio daily this week (30 XP). **ACTION 2:** Create your vision board and upload a photo (40 XP). **ACTION 3:** Share your board in the group (20 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 4 · Partner Involvement Basics.